

The Ban Fell, the Book Stood

Edwin Giltay

Abstract In 2016 the Court of Appeal of The Hague lifted a complete publication and speaking ban imposed in 2015 on the Dutch non-fiction book *De doofpotgeneraal* (*The Cover-up General*), explicitly dismissing doubts about the meticulousness with which it was written. This essay traces the affair the book documents: a military intelligence operation surrounding suppressed photographic evidence of the 1995 Srebrenica genocide, the infiltration of a civilian workplace in Delft, and an almost three-decade pattern of institutional silence. It sets out how the book served as evidence in the Mothers of Srebrenica's litigation against the Dutch State, which culminated in the Supreme Court's 2019 ruling on partial state liability, and it documents the contradictory positions taken by successive ministers. The essay argues that the persistent refusal of the ministries involved to respond substantively is itself the story: documented truth facing institutional denial.

Keywords: Srebrenica, censorship, press freedom, military intelligence, cover-up, the Netherlands

The events in this affair are so unusual that virtually every fact in this essay is backed by a source.

A Unique Precedent

On 12 April 2016, the Court of Appeal of The Hague issued a landmark ruling: it lifted both the full ban on *The Cover-up General* and the speaking ban on its author. But the court did more than restore freedom of speech: "Unlike the preliminary relief judge, the Court of Appeal holds that these inaccuracies [an age and the spelling of a name] are also insufficient to cast doubt on the meticulousness with which [author Edwin Giltay] proceeded in writing the book".¹ The claimant, a former employee of military intelligence service MID who appears in it, had also demanded that Giltay declare his own work pure fiction in three national newspapers. The court established precisely the opposite. The role she plays in the book is not "purely invented" or "complete fiction".²

This combination of a total ban reversed and the judicial rehabilitation of the author is virtually unequalled. The Banned Books Museum calls it "a very rare example in our collection of an author who successfully challenged a book ban".³ That same judgment, moreover, sums up the book's core claim, in the court's own words, that "the roll of film with photographs that a soldier of Dutchbat [the Dutch UN battalion] took in Srebrenica was not destroyed by accident, but was deliberately withheld by the MID". The court did not establish its truth, but it did rule that the claim belongs to "a debate of public interest" and that a ban would affect "the fundamental freedom of expression at its core".⁴

In Dutch legal history, this precedent is unique. While writers like the nineteenth-century Dutch author Multatuli triumphed over attacks on specific passages, *The Cover-up General* is, as far as is known, the only Dutch book whose total ban⁵ was judicially reversed. That reversal was possible because the ban was legally weak,

the subject matter of direct public importance, and the evidence overwhelming. For instance, the claimant reproached the author for a spelling error in her name, while correspondence surfaced that proved in black and white that she had misspelled her own name.⁶

The judgment has been included in the legal literature (RAV 2016/75,⁷ NJF 2016/242⁸) and has since been cited as a benchmark by judges in press freedom cases, including in summary proceedings brought in vain by the President of Suriname against a book about government corruption.⁹ The legal victory, however, is only part of the story. What makes this case significant is what *The Cover-up General* brings to light, and how the government has responded. Or more precisely, how it hasn't.

The Government Contradicts Itself

The Dutch government's response to this judicially scrutinised book reveals a striking internal contradiction. The Minister of Justice stated in 2021 that *The Cover-up General* is "in no way" considered fake news, conspiracy theory or anti-government propaganda.¹⁰ He thereby ruled out all three disqualifying labels, in line with the 2016 ruling. Yet in 2018, the Minister of Defence dismissed it as a book in which "fact and fiction do indeed become intertwined".¹¹ This confronts the public with an impossible choice.

The failure to speak with one voice is constitutionally problematic. Dutch ministers are obliged to maintain consistent government policy, yet here they take opposing positions on the same work, whose meticulousness the court had already confirmed in 2016. One minister acknowledges its factual basis while another dismisses it as a blend of truth and fabrication. Who is correct: the Minister of Justice, or the Minister of Defence who has refused clarification for decades? In 2017, the Parliamentary Defence Committee unanimously decided that the Minister of Defence should provide a substantive response to the book's allegations.^{12, 13} Yet that answer has never come. Can a government serve as arbiter of truth when its own ministers contradict each other?

What the Book Reveals: Srebrenica Cover-Up

What prompted this institutional silence? *The Cover-up General* documents in precise detail how a Dutch military intelligence operation spiralled out of control. This operation involved surveillance of civilians at their workplace and the suppression of photographic evidence related to the 1995 Srebrenica genocide, in which over 8,000 Bosniaks (Bosnian Muslims) were murdered after Dutch UN troops failed to protect their enclave. The film captured Bosnian Serb war crimes, evidence that the Dutch military sought to obscure.¹⁴

The book recounts how this operation began with military intelligence officer Barbara Overduyn's infiltration of Giltay's civilian workplace in Delft in 1998. This involved, among other things, a break-in and photographic surveillance, of which Overduyn herself was the target.¹⁵ She had approached Giltay while openly discussing internal opposition within her intelligence service to the suppression of the Srebrenica photos. The roll, she said, had not failed at all: it was simply "stored in the archives of the MID".¹⁶

After Giltay filed a complaint with the National Ombudsman, Overduyn accused him of being "irritating", "maladjusted" and "completely insane".¹⁷ She made those statements in an investigation the MID opened into itself. That was agreed within the service on 26 January 1999, between its deputy head and the Ombudsman's case officer.¹⁸ In his response to the Ombudsman, the Minister of Defence adopted the report of that self-investigation, drawn up on the instructions of that same deputy head, as his official position. In doing so, the Ministry shifted the focus: to a complaint about Defence it answered with a judgement on the complainant's character.

That this essay turns to the author here is not because his case weighs more heavily than that of the bereaved. It is because discrediting the messenger has for almost thirty years been the way to keep the message shut out: where did the Srebrenica photographs go?

Giltay reported the ministerial statements about him as libel to the Chief Public Prosecutor in June 1999.¹⁹ Two weeks later, both the Head of the Military Intelligence Service and his deputy were removed from their posts by the Minister over a "serious error of judgement".^{20, 21} When Giltay, assisted by lawyer Gerard Spong,²² also sought to file a criminal complaint with the police in July 1999, the detectives refused to record it. In March 2000 the district chief upheld Giltay's grievance about this on two points and offered his apologies.²³ Only then, in June 2000, was the complaint of slander and libel recorded by The Hague police.

In that complaint Giltay also put on record what Overduyn had said about the photographic material: "Unprompted, she stated that the failure of the so-called failed development of the photographs taken was a fabrication, and that she had seen the photos herself".²⁴ Later that year, Giltay sought the help of Her Majesty Queen Beatrix over the stalling of this Srebrenica-related criminal complaint. An intervention followed: the head of state referred his letter to the Minister of the Interior for handling.²⁵ This prompted The Hague's mayor Wim Deetman to formally acknowledge to Giltay that his police force had acted wrongly towards him.^{26, 27}

However, the Minister's characterisation remains online today, in the National Ombudsman's public report of 1999.²⁸ This despite considerable contradictory evidence: a Defence assessment from 1998 that attested to a strong character,²⁹ professional references from multinationals including IBM and Deloitte,^{30, 31, 32, 33} the court's recognition of Giltay's working method,³⁴ and Overduyn's own later admission that her claims about him were refuted.³⁵ Although the characterisation has never been withdrawn by Defence, Minister of Defence Ank Bijleveld bluntly denied in 2018 that the ministry had ever spoken of Giltay in such terms.³⁶ That this characterisation was in fact made is recorded not only in that Ombudsman report. Since August 1999 it has been set down in black and white at the Public Prosecution

Service.³⁷ It has been on the court record since 2002: a decision of the Court of Appeal of The Hague recorded at the time that Overduyn, “working at the MID”, had indeed declared that Giltay was “completely insane”.³⁸

A Cover-Up with an International Dimension

While the libel case remained a domestic matter, the cover-up surrounding the photographic material reached into international justice. At the International Criminal Tribunal for the former Yugoslavia in The Hague, the roll of film came up in the trial of Radovan Karadžić, the Bosnian Serb leader who was sentenced to life imprisonment in part for the genocide in Srebrenica. In 2011, during the testimony of Johannes Rutten, the lieutenant of Dutchbat III who on 13 July 1995 photographed the bodies of executed Bosniaks at Potočari, it was recorded that on his return he handed his roll of film over to the MID. He was subsequently told that the photos had failed to develop.³⁹

It was counter-intelligence Major De Ruyter who took receipt of the roll.⁴⁰ The NIOD report, the official inquiry into the fall of Srebrenica commissioned by the cabinet, records that, during training, he had told the battalion that the population of the enclave consisted of “nothing but scum”.⁴¹ The same major conducted the February 1999 interview with Overduyn from which the ministerial position emerged that Giltay was “completely insane”.⁴² On 6 December 2002 he testified under oath about the fate of that same roll before the Parliamentary Committee of Inquiry on Srebrenica.⁴³ The dehumanisation of the Muslim population, the vanished evidence and the branding of the witness as insane thus share not only a ministry, but a single official.

Rutten’s roll does not stand alone. In late 2016, lawyers Klaas Arjen Krikke and Michael Ruperti announced that, on behalf of more than two hundred members of Dutchbat III, they would seek a court order for access to photographic material which they said lies in the archive of the Military Intelligence and Security Service (MIVD), as the MID is now called: prints of at least eight rolls of film.⁴⁴ Whether that claim was ever filed has never become public. Under Chapter VII of the UN Charter, all states, the Netherlands included, were obliged to cooperate fully with the tribunal, up to and including the production of evidence.⁴⁵ When Giltay asked the tribunal about the rolls,⁴⁶ the Office of the Prosecutor replied on 3 October 2017 that it had no knowledge of the “8 photo rolls”.⁴⁷ The prosecutors who brought the genocide cases thus knew nothing of them.

How much weight the Dutch failure in Srebrenica carries was settled politically long ago: in 2002 the entire cabinet resigned following the NIOD report.⁴⁸ The rolls of film belong to that same dossier. De Ruyter maintained in his hearing before the parliamentary committee of inquiry that Rutten’s roll had failed during development: it was, in his words, an accumulation of “situations in which Murphy’s law struck”, in short “just bad luck”.⁴⁹ Yet that account remained contested, despite multiple official investigations, even within the armed forces themselves. General Hans Couzy, who in 1995 commanded the Dutch army to which Dutchbat belonged, gave his own account in 1998: the MID wanted to develop it itself, after which it was lost there. He called it “a story that naturally no one believes”.⁵⁰

Hans Laroes, former editor-in-chief of NOS News (Dutch public television news), also wrote in his 2014 epilogue to *The Cover-up General* about the story that the roll had failed during development: “Nobody I talked to believed any of it. There was no journalist around who did not doubt the official line, with a hint of cynicism”.⁵¹ The 2015 total ban covered his epilogue too. Thus, even his widely shared scepticism was silenced at the time.

More Than a Banned Book

The international attention *The Cover-up General* received reflects not only curiosity about a banned title, but also concern about what it reveals: evidence of institutional cover-up in the aftermath of the Srebrenica genocide. In July 2015, the Mothers of Srebrenica cited it as an illustration of precisely the cover-up pattern it describes. In their statement of appeal against the Dutch State it appears in the passage on the destruction of photographic and video material.⁵² That was no coincidence: their lawyers had followed the book from the outset.⁵³ Simon van der Sluijs attended the launch of the first edition in November 2014, and as early as February 2015 he and his colleague Marco Gerritsen put their weight behind it: “Edwin Giltay describes how his rights were sacrificed by the State to keep the lid on the cover-up surrounding the Srebrenica roll of film. Once again, this feeds the suspicion that the State is responsible for the disappearance of the notorious roll of film”.⁵⁴

Even before *The Cover-up General* appeared, it had won support from an unimpeachable quarter: former Minister Jan Pronk, who took political responsibility for the failure of the Dutch UN mission in Srebrenica, called it “meticulously written and well documented”.⁵⁵ Although the State did not refute the book’s content in the Mothers’ lawsuit, the book did not go unchallenged in military intelligence circles. By her own account, Overduyn approached the Ministry of Defence, which turned out to be aware of the work but decided not to take action itself.⁵⁶ Overduyn then demanded a complete publication and speaking ban, which the District Court imposed in December 2015.⁵⁷ Prohibited were not only distribution, publication and reprinting, but also further promotion of the book “at lectures, book presentations and other public utterances”, under penalty of up to €100,000. The ban thereby affected even Giltay’s freedom to speak about his own life.

Giltay defended himself with media lawyer Jurian van Groenendaal at his side,⁵⁸ after which the Court of Appeal overturned the ban in 2016. In 2019, in the Mothers’ case, the Supreme Court established Dutch liability at ten per cent of the damages suffered by the surviving relatives of approximately 350 men who were sent away from the Dutchbat compound on 13 July 1995.⁵⁹

For the surviving relatives it came to a fraction of what they had claimed; two years earlier the Court of Appeal had still put liability at thirty per cent.⁶⁰ In that same statement of appeal their lawyers had already written that it “at the very least has the appearance that the State, through the intervention of the military intelligence and security service, deliberately destroyed or is withholding the photos in question from the notorious film roll”.⁶¹ For the claim that Rutten’s film roll had never failed, they referred to four pages from *The Cover-up General*.⁶²

The book's impact extends far beyond the courtroom. The censorship backfired: the attempt to ban it propelled the story around the world.^{63, 64} Giltay added eight chapters on the battle against censorship to the second edition,⁶⁵ and two more to the third. Over four hundred publications and mentions of the book have since appeared, from newspapers and broadcasters to reference works and forums, and from Brazil to Indonesia.^{66, 67} That press attention is not a tribute but a question asked time and again that the Ministry of Defence leaves unanswered: what did the Military Intelligence Service have to hide?

Three Affairs

At a single civilian workplace in Delft, the traces of three affairs in post-war Dutch history converged: Srebrenica, the IRT affair (a 1990s Dutch policing scandal), and a secret honey-trap programme. These were not parallel dossiers. They intersected there. The book thus focuses "only in part" on the withholding of an infamous photographic film.⁶⁸

In the same small department of the civilian company that Overduyn infiltrated in 1998, another woman also worked, who had ended up in a life-threatening situation. She had fled her provincial town as a result, as Giltay heard in 1998. Moreover, as he learned in 1999 from an entirely different source, she had been placed in a witness protection programme by the Ministry of Justice. (For the safety of his former colleague, Giltay remained silent about this until 2026 and leaves further substantiation aside here.) Through no fault of her own, she had become caught up in a corruption scandal surrounding the IRT affair, in which police and prosecutors infiltrated organised drug crime. While the Ministry of Justice had supported her as a protected witness in building a new life, the Ministry of Defence subsequently turned her workplace in Delft into a covert observation post for an intelligence operation.

In other words, the left hand of the State compromised what the right hand was supposed to protect. The monitoring of the threatened witness at this workplace remained out of Giltay's sight, as Overduyn, during her infiltration, directed his interest towards her intelligence service and Srebrenica. The fact that this intelligence operation was taking place directly alongside the 'protected' civilian woman was explained away to Giltay in 1999 as mere coincidence. This coincidence had, however, aroused intelligence interest in the department.⁶⁹ This raises the question of whether the State had an independent interest in monitoring this woman, given her role as a witness in a state corruption case.

The Cover-up General not only exposes these intelligence operations. The book, whose meticulousness was validated by the Court of Appeal of The Hague,⁷⁰ also describes a separate honey-trap programme run by the Dutch Domestic Security Service (BVD), which was kept from Parliament and for which Giltay was approached in 1992.⁷¹ In 2015, the Minister of the Interior, Ronald Plasterk, responsible for the BVD's successor, stated that he had taken note of the manuscript. He added: "I shall not respond substantively to this any further".⁷² At the author's request, however, he ordered an official investigation by the CTIVD, the oversight committee for the intelligence services,⁷³ which he withdrew 46 days later.⁷⁴

The convergence of three affairs may help explain why the State has remained so persistently silent: acknowledging the findings on the Military Intelligence Service would lend credibility to the revelations about the Domestic Security Service, and vice versa. Moreover, acknowledging that the State neglected its duty of care surrounding witness protection could call the entire programme into question. The result is a government speaking with three voices: rejection (Defence), silence (Interior) and confirmation without substantive explanation (Justice).

Never a Substantive Answer

This pattern is not a recent development. Despite the judicial validation and international impact of the book, the ministries named within it have never responded substantively to its revelations, at any level. The silence began even before publication. As early as 30 October 2000, the Minister of Defence rejected a request for rehabilitation with the closing line: “No further letters from you will be answered”.⁷⁵

On 20 November 2010, the author sent a confidential letter⁷⁶ to the parliamentary group leaders Job Cohen, Stef Blok and Geert Wilders, at the time also members of the Committee on the Intelligence and Security Services. Enclosed was a detailed witness report of this affair, an early manuscript version of *The Cover-up General*. What happened to the letter after it was received, Giltay never learned. Six weeks later, on the night of 31 December 2010 to 1 January 2011, a fire broke out in Giltay’s storage unit in The Hague, situated in a locked storage corridor alongside and beneath six flats. The police recorded the fire as arson.⁷⁷ His paper dossier was lost in the fire; digital copies, however, have been preserved at multiple locations. A connection to the content of his testimony is unlikely but cannot be ruled out: the perpetrator has never been traced.

More than three years later, in March 2014, the Ministers of Defence and of the Interior received the full manuscript of *The Cover-up General* ahead of publication, accompanied by a formal notification and a deadline for a response, confirmed by a signed acknowledgement of receipt.^{78, 79} That the manuscript was sent to both ministers before publication with a request to respond has moreover stood, since 2016, as an undisputed fact in the appeal judgment.⁸⁰ The ministers chose not to reply. There was no substantive response upon publication, nor when the ban was lifted in 2016 with judicial praise.

In June 2017, the Ministry of Defence rejected a request to retract the 1999 ministerial declaration of insanity, citing the Ombudsman report from that same year and a CTIVD investigation. Both bodies were said to have declared Giltay’s complaints about the MIVD unfounded.⁸¹

Both pillars of this position, however, had been refuted years earlier. The Ombudsman report had been undermined when the Court of Appeal of The Hague explicitly dismissed the doubts about the author’s meticulousness.⁸² Moreover, within two months of the report’s publication, the Ombudsman himself had already written to Giltay: “It is not the case that the National Ombudsman regards the account of the former MID employee concerned as absolute truth, and your account thereby as untrue”.⁸³ The CTIVD investigation, the second pillar, did not exist, and this had

been on the record since 2009: two successive chairs had confirmed at the time that the committee had not handled Giltay's complaint, because Defence had never submitted the request for advice that this required.^{84, 85} General Onno Eichelsheim, Director of the MIVD and Chief of Defence since 2021, ultimately confirmed this himself. He wrote to Giltay in October 2017: "The CTIVD has not handled any complaint from you against the MIVD. There is therefore no CTIVD report either".⁸⁶

Likewise in 2017, the Parliamentary Defence Committee unanimously demanded that the Minister address the allegations. That decision had been preceded by an intervention by Speaker of the House Khadija Arib: she forwarded Giltay's letter to the Standing Committee on Defence.⁸⁷ The official ministerial reply that followed, however, sidestepped the military intelligence affair entirely.⁸⁸ Minister Ank Bijleveld, asked about the case in 2018, simply stated: "Defence has no further opinion on that".⁸⁹ After the Supreme Court of the Netherlands ruled in 2019 that the Netherlands is partially liable for around 350 Srebrenica deaths,⁹⁰ in the case in which the Mothers' lawyers relied on the book, Giltay again heard nothing from Defence. In 2020, he formally invited Defence once more to answer on the merits, this time with a view to a translation.⁹¹ The Minister replied that she "has no need to respond substantively to your book", without giving any legal grounds for that refusal.⁹²

The State is silent not only about the book, but also about the treatment of its author. A Dutch handbook on investigative practice sets out when an intelligence service may take disruption measures: against "antidemocratic activities, activities dangerous to the State, or other activities" directed against the interests the law protects. As an example of such a measure it cites "spreading disinformation".⁹³ What has happened to Giltay since 1998 bears the hallmarks of such measures. Overduyn told a former colleague that Giltay's background was bad and ordered him to break off contact.⁹⁴ The ministerial characterisation of 1999, which has been maintained ever since, emerged from an interview with her conducted by De Ruyter, the counter-intelligence major who also took receipt of the film roll.

None of the three grounds in the handbook has ever been invoked against Giltay. "Danger to the State" was ruled out in writing by the Minister of Justice in 2021.⁹⁵ Nor does "antidemocratic" fit a citizen who turned to the Ombudsman, the public prosecutor, the police, government ministers, the head of state, the courts and Parliament. That leaves the residual category: other interests of the State. In 2014, before publication, the manuscript was in the hands of the Ministers of Defence and of the Interior. They were free to argue that state secrets, military security interests or ongoing operations were at stake. They did not do so: neither Defence in 2014 nor the Interior a week later. The same was true in 2015, when Minister Plasterk refused to respond substantively to Giltay's repeated notification about the honey-trap programme. The CTIVD investigation he opened at the author's request was withdrawn 46 days later without any invocation of state security. Nor did Defence invoke that ground in 2020.

In short, seven moments, three ministries, one pattern: not one invocation of a state secret. This silence is not statutory secrecy. It is a choice. When Defence, in June 2017, did give reasons for refusing to withdraw the declaration of insanity, it invoked not state security but the refuted Ombudsman report and a CTIVD investigation that did not exist.⁹⁶ Nor did that reasoning address the content of the book.

And when the Minister, at Parliament's request, did briefly address the book in October 2017, he dismissed the film-roll thesis by citing the 2002 NIOD report and said nothing about the intelligence affair, again without invoking state security.⁹⁷ Of the three grounds for disruption measures, then, one has been ruled out by Justice, one is incompatible with the path Giltay took, and one has never been invoked by any minister.

In 2022 Giltay delivered the third revised edition in person for the attention of the new Minister of Defence, Kajsa Ollongren, with a covering letter in which he expressed the hope that she would set right the mistakes of her predecessors.⁹⁸ No response came from Defence. The silence extends even to the film roll. Although Agfa photo experts in Munich concluded that the roll had been so thoroughly destroyed that this could only have been done deliberately,⁹⁹ Defence persists with the narrative of a development error, and has never revised that position. It is not the only destruction of documentation in this affair that has remained officially unexplained.

The Silence Is the Story

This persistence creates an unprecedented asymmetry: the gulf between the documented establishment of the facts and the enduring absence of institutional accountability remains unbridged. In a functioning democracy with robust accountability mechanisms, such sustained refusal to engage with a book that has withstood judicial scrutiny would be impossible. That it continues is not a gap in this story. *It is the story.*

The situation resembles a chess match where one player, facing inevitable checkmate, simply refuses to make another move. What happens when a player neither acknowledges the evidence nor refutes it? They avoid formal defeat, but does that change the outcome? Whoever surveys the board can judge the position for themselves. The silence of the ministries reveals precisely the cover-up mentality this book exposes: an institutional inability to confront uncomfortable truths about controversial intelligence operations, one of which is linked to the greatest failure in modern Dutch history. And the audience grows. Every new publication, in whatever language, gathers new witnesses around the board.

Obstruction Backfires

In 2023, Giltay once again scored victories over state obstruction. The National Ombudsman had literally locked away his file "in the safe".¹⁰⁰ In 2018, after the judicial rehabilitation, Giltay had submitted nine specific grievances to the National Ombudsman, backed up by a dossier of 19 pieces of evidence. He had also previously delivered copies of his book, containing extensive additional documentation, to the Ombudsman's office, partly at the request of its own staff.¹⁰¹ The Ombudsman, however, refused to address the grievances on the merits and unilaterally ended the correspondence with a one-page letter: further letters would be archived without reply.¹⁰²

The Hague District Court punished this obstruction in 2023. It ruled that the institution had wrongfully blocked Giltay's information request,¹⁰³ and in a subsequent

ruling even imposed penalty payments.¹⁰⁴ In paying that penalty in 2024, the National Ombudsman made a calculation error.¹⁰⁵ Only after Giltay had announced in June 2026 that he would take the matter to the civil court did he correct the error.^{106, 107, 108}

With the court-ordered funds, Giltay financed the translation and free worldwide distribution of the English edition,¹⁰⁹ turning state obstruction into global accessibility. In 2024, this international edition was launched at the Banned Books Museum in Tallinn, Estonia, which added it to its collection next to the ‘banned’ Dutch edition.¹¹⁰ The story kept surfacing in unexpected places. In 2025, Grok, the chatbot of Elon Musk’s company xAI, publicly endorsed *The Cover-up General* on X.¹¹¹ By xAI’s account this was its first corporate book recommendation.¹¹²

In the archives, too, this affair is now irreversibly recorded. In June 2026, the national library KB selected the book’s documentary website for inclusion in its web collection,¹¹³ in line with the UNESCO Charter on the Preservation of the Digital Heritage.¹¹⁴ From 12 July 2026, the day after the Srebrenica commemoration, the site was archived, including the e-books and source documents published there, and thereby preserved beyond the author’s reach in the Depot of Dutch Publications. That same month, both editions were deposited in the open archive hosted by the European research centre CERN in Geneva,^{115, 116} so that they remain permanently accessible and citable.

The Cover-up General now sits in the collections that preserve the very history it describes: from the Peace Palace in The Hague¹¹⁷ and the NIOD Institute for War, Holocaust and Genocide Studies in Amsterdam¹¹⁸ to the National and University Library in Sarajevo¹¹⁹ and the Srebrenica Memorial Centre in Potočari.¹²⁰ In September 2026 the Wiener Holocaust Library in London joined them, cataloguing the English edition under the subject keywords genocide, intelligence services and censorship.¹²¹

Giltay’s case is included in an ongoing study by Prof. Andrew Hales of the University of Mississippi into the effects of book censorship.¹²² At home, *The Cover-up General* features on the recommended-reading list of Week van het Verboden Boek,¹²³ the free-expression campaign which this year runs from 19 to 27 September. Each new repository and each new mention adds a witness to the same unanswered question, while clarification from the Ministry of Defence remains absent.

Cracks in the Wall

Notably, *The Cover-up General* sits on the shelves of three Defence libraries: the Royal Military Academy, the Royal Naval College, and the Netherlands Institute of Military History.¹²⁴ The Ministry of Defence makes it available for its own officers to read.

Even the Ministry’s own people have contradicted its 1999 declaration of insanity. As early as 1998, its own psychological assessment concluded Giltay had a strong character,¹²⁵ the opposite of mentally unstable. In 2016, Overduyn acknowledged in court documents that Giltay had disproved her claims with evidence.¹²⁶ Yet the Ministry’s response to Giltay’s 2017 retraction request was unequivocal: “I therefore

consider your case closed".¹²⁷ A year later, Minister of Defence Ank Bijleveld publicly praised Giltay's military acuity on social media.¹²⁸

This pattern of contradiction extends even to the oversight body itself. The interview reports in the 1999 Ministry of Defence document were incorporated word for word, as the Minister's official position, into a public Ombudsman report.¹²⁹ Yet a quarter of a century later, in 2024, the institution's own senior legal adviser Karin Vaalburg praised *The Cover-up General*. A former lieutenant colonel who represented the Ombudsman against Giltay in related court cases, she wrote in her work correspondence: "My compliments on the very extensive underlying documentation and level of detail in the story!"¹³⁰ This on-the-record praise came from the very institution whose 1999 report remains online today.

End the Silence for Srebrenica

The Cover-up General has been challenged, brushed aside and met with silence, but never substantively refuted. It is a work of investigative journalism that held up before the Court of Appeal, that opponents acknowledge and that the Ministry of Justice has not designated as fake news. A genuine controversy exists only when two sides exchange arguments. Here one side put hundreds of documents on the table, while the other maintained almost three decades of obstruction and silence. Is that a controversy, or documented truth facing institutional denial?

The pillars of the democratic rule of law provide the book's decisive validations. Six independent authorities substantiate what the Ministry of Defence refuses to acknowledge:

1. **Survivors:** Srebrenica survivors cited the book as evidence in their proceedings against the State, in the passage on the destruction of photographic and video material.¹³¹
2. **Judiciary:** The Court of Appeal lifted the publication and speaking bans and explicitly dismissed the doubts cast on the book's meticulousness.¹³²
3. **Parliament:** Parliament acknowledged the gravity of the matter by unanimously demanding answers from the Minister of Defence.¹³³
4. **Ministry:** The Minister of Justice confirmed it is not disinformation.¹³⁴
5. **Oversight:** The senior legal adviser of the National Ombudsman, whose institution lost twice to Giltay in court, praised the book's documentation in her official capacity.¹³⁵
6. **Procedure:** The court ruled that this Ombudsman unlawfully blocked Giltay's information request,¹³⁶ corroborating the book's pattern of institutional obstruction.

The book itself has never been refuted. The same goes for the professional references and the military assessment of the author's character, both cited above. The Ministry of Defence's chief witness could not undermine any of it. She had secured a temporary ban on the book in 2015, but acknowledged in court documents that her specific claims about the author had been disproved by evidence. Yet the Ministry

of Defence continues to maintain her refuted position even after her death in 2024.¹³⁷

But this is no longer about one whistleblower's credibility. This is about whether a democratic state can continue to contradict its own courts, its own Minister of Justice, its own victims, and the documented historical record. The Ministry's refusal to retract its refuted report is not merely personal: it hampers investigation into the intelligence scandal surrounding the genocide. As long as discrediting the messenger remains state policy, the message itself can never be addressed. Personal rehabilitation is not the end goal, but an indispensable prerequisite for historical responsibility.

No Other Option Left

On 25 March 2026, the author spoke with Judge Solomy Balungi Bossa of the International Criminal Court. As keynote guest, she participated in a public debate at Amare, The Hague,¹³⁸ within sight of the Ministry of Defence. In the context of Srebrenica and this book, he asked her what she thought of those who cover up evidence of war crimes. Her answer was unambiguous: "They should be brought to justice".¹³⁹

At stake is accountability for Srebrenica. This book supplied the Mothers of Srebrenica with evidence for their claim that the photographs of the genocide are being withheld. In 2019, the Supreme Court of the Netherlands ruled that the Dutch State is partially liable for the deaths of about 350 men. The Ministry of Defence's continued radio silence creates the impression that institutional self-preservation outweighs historical truth about Europe's only genocide since the Holocaust.

For Srebrenica survivors today, this means over thirty years of struggle since 11 July 1995 to obtain the answers they deserve. For Dutchbat veterans, this means waiting for the release of their photographs, which they took at the time, some at personal risk, only for them to be seized.¹⁴⁰ For the Ministry of Defence, this means a deadlocked position in which silence is becoming increasingly costly, legally, morally, and geopolitically. That is also literally true: fighting the Srebrenica cases cost the State over 2.6 million euros in legal fees between 2003 and 2021, figures that became public after a freedom-of-information request by the author.¹⁴¹

Truth requires courage, especially when it touches a national trauma. That courage deserves recognition when it comes. Transparency ultimately offers the only sustainable way forward: not as a threat to the officials involved, but as a prerequisite for institutions to regain public trust.

There is no other option left: end the silence about Srebrenica. The truth about the genocide deserves no less. The mothers are still waiting.

Edwin Giltay is a Dutch investigative journalist and editor based in The Hague. He is the author of De doofpotgeneraal (2014; third revised edition 2025) and its English edition The Cover-up General (2024), both freely available worldwide as e-books. His documentary website on the affair runs in Dutch, English, German, French and Bosnian at www.thecoverupgeneral.com.

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Endnotes

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⁴² Military Intelligence Service (MID), internal report 'Intern onderzoek GILTAY', no. Det/51/99, 12 February 1999, recording the interview with Overduyn of 11 February 1999 and signed by Major R.F.J.H. de Ruijter; www.dedoofpotgeneraal.nl/doc/chef-staf-mid.pdf. The spelling of his surname varies across the sources: the Parliamentary Committee of Inquiry used 'De Ruyter', while he signs this report with the 'ij' variant. The radio programme Argos identified him as counter-intelligence Major Rob de Ruyter and named him together with his liaison officer E. Rave, the same pair who drew up this report. Such variation is a professional practice rather than an inconsistency in the record: the handbook *Informatie en Opsporing* instructs agents that they may act 'under cover of an assumed identity or capacity, for example by using a false name' (D. van der Bel, A.M. van Hoorn and J.J.T.M. Pieters, *Informatie en opsporing*, Zeist: Kerckebosch, 2009), and the names of intelligence officers are in many cases deliberately misspelled, a false spelling being less far-reaching than an entirely new cover identity. See Edwin Giltay, *The Cover-up General* (The Hague: author, 2024), pp. 144 and 161–162; www.dedoofpotgeneraal.nl/book.pdf.

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- ⁵⁶ Barbara Overduyn's writ of summons (*dagvaarding*) against Giltay in preliminary relief proceedings, 2015; www.dedoofpotgeneraal.nl/doc/dagvaarding.pdf.
- ⁵⁷ District Court of The Hague, judgment in preliminary relief proceedings of 14 December 2015, case no. C/09/497903 / KG ZA 15/1556, ECLI:NL:RBDHA:2015:15050, operative part (the prohibition and the €100,000 penalty); <https://uitspraken.rechtspraak.nl/details?id=ECLI:NL:RBDHA:2015:15050>.
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- ⁹⁰ Supreme Court of the Netherlands, judgment of 19 July 2019, ECLI:NL:HR:2019:1223; <https://deeplink.rechtspraak.nl/uitspraak?id=ECLI:NL:HR:2019:1223>.
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Appendix: A selection of the media coverage

The coverage below spans press, radio, television and online media in more than a dozen countries across five continents. Country codes: AL Albania · BA Bosnia and Herzegovina · EE Estonia · EU European Union · GB United Kingdom · ID Indonesia · IT Italy · ME Montenegro · MK North Macedonia · NL the Netherlands · QA Qatar · RS Serbia · SI Slovenia · SR Suriname · TR Turkey · US United States · XK Kosovo · ZA South Africa.

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